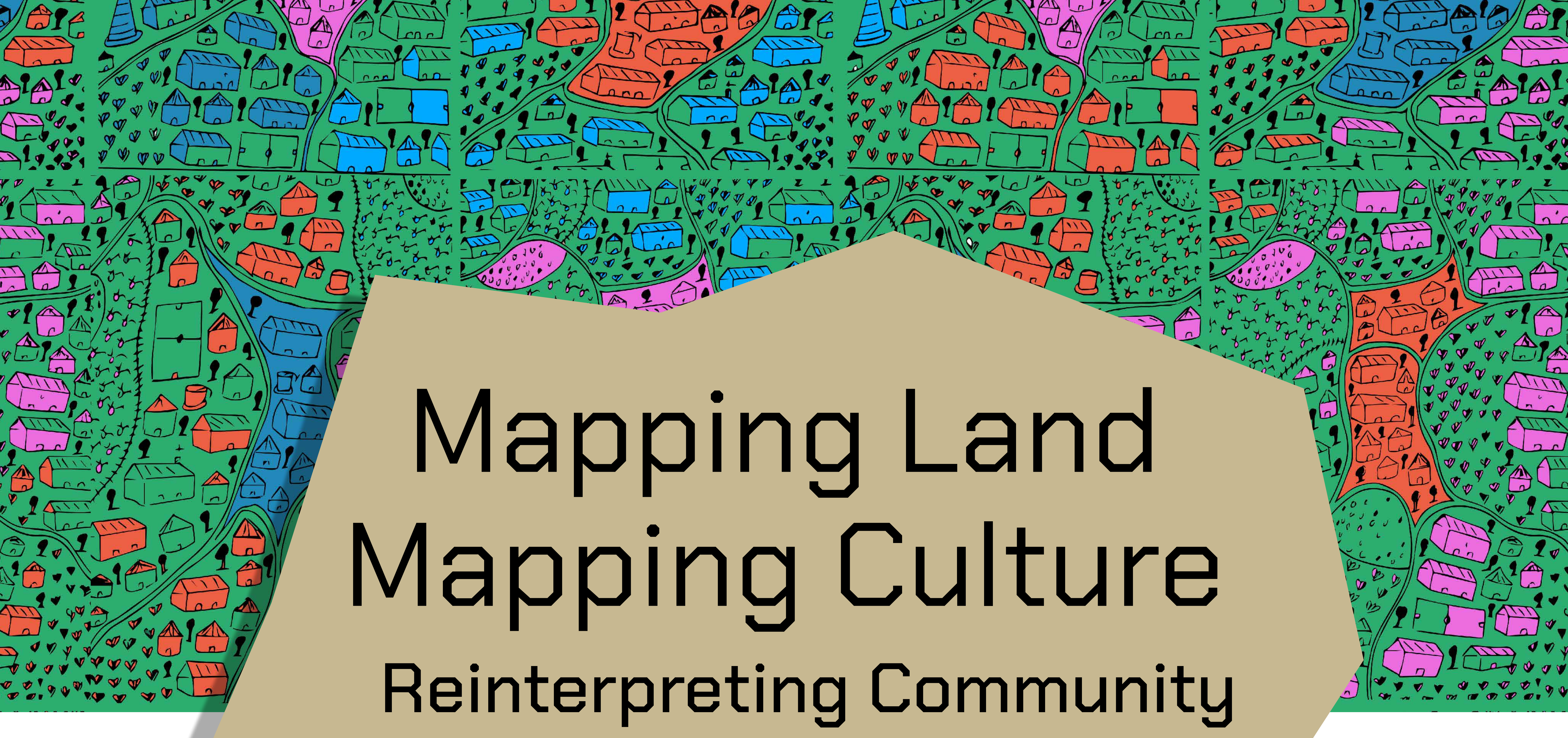




Mapping Land Mapping Culture

Reinterpreting Community Narratives through Art

Land ownership is a cornerstone in shaping economic prosperity, social stability, and sustainable development at local, regional, and national levels. The land delimitation process in rural communities invites women, children, and elders to participate by sketching and mapping their communities, highlighting essential infrastructure, cultural landmarks, local resources, and other aspects they consider meaningful.

These sketches, captured by the Terra Vital Consortium team as part of the World Bank Terra Segura project, were incorporated into community master plans to guide future development. Recognizing their significance, the Terra Vital team understood that these maps transcend mere geographical guides highlighting physical attributes; they are intimate portraits of individuals and communities and their relationship with their land. Each line, symbol, and annotation encode layers of life experiences.

Acknowledging the artistic value of these sketches, Terra Vital launched an art challenge. Participants were invited to reinterpret the landscape sketches as "High Art", encouraging shifts in perspective, and adding new layers of meaning for diverse audiences.

Bruno Sserunkuma, a renowned artist and head of the Ceramic Department at Makerere University in Kampala, Uganda, was selected for the project. A recipient of the UNESCO Crafts Prize for his contributions to preserving traditional art forms, Sserunkuma proposed to embed the sketches within broader narratives of rural African communities through two distinct approaches:

Clay vases: Sserunkuma used his distinctive style, renowned for its circular, infinite narrations depicting the oral history of his Buganda people in Uganda. This approach linked the visual culture depicted by rural people in Mozambique to larger themes of land ownership and distribution in contemporary Africa, offering a unique artistic perspective on these critical issues.

Printed fabrics: Sserunkuma's decision to print rural landscape sketches on imported Chinese synthetic fabric represents a nuanced commentary on Africa's evolving physical, economic, and cultural landscape. For centuries, wax prints on cotton (Ankara) symbolized African identity, despite their colonial origins. Following independence, the African textile industry emerged as a powerful symbol of liberation and economic autonomy, challenging perceptions of the continent as merely a supplier of raw materials. Locally produced wax cloth came to embody economic aspirations and cultural pride.

Sserunkuma's use of synthetic cloth imported from China signals a shift in this narrative. His work highlights the tension between preserving traditional crafts and adapting to modern market forces, pointing to the complex relationship between local cultures, resource management, and emerging forms of economic engagement with global powers.



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